KPPSC PMS • EUROPEAN HISTORY (PAPER I) ## QUESTION 12: POLITICAL PHILOSOPHY IN EUROPE: JOHN LOCKE & JEAN-JACQUES ROUSSEAU

EXECUTIVE EXAM METADATA - **EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED: 2022 Q.8: 'Assess the contribution of the following philosophers in changing the political thought of Europe: (a) John Locke, (b) Jean-Jacques Rousseau.' - **SYLLABUS TOPIC:** Paper I — Section 1: Intellectual Foundations of Modern Europe — Political Philosophy of the Enlightenment - **ALLOCATED MARKS / TIME:** 20 Marks (10 Marks each for Locke and Rousseau) | 35 Minutes | Standard Word Count: ~650–700 words - **HISTORIOGRAPHICAL THESIS:** John Locke and Jean-Jacques Rousseau radically transformed European political consciousness by dismantling divine-right patriarchal absolutism and establishing contractual, secular legitimacy; while Locke provided the empirical, individualistic architecture for liberal constitutionalism, private property, and limited government, Rousseau articulated a radical, communitarian vision of popular sovereignty and the General Will that laid the intellectual powder-keg for modern democratic republicanism and mass revolution.**

📌 EXAM ESSENTIAL TAKEAWAY > • John Locke (1632–1704) — The Architect of Liberal Constitutionalism: In 'Two Treatises of Government' (1689), refuted Robert Filmer's divine right theory. Articulated that all human beings in the State of Nature possess inalienable Natural Rights: 'Life, Liberty, and Estate (Property).' Government is a conditional fiduciary trust; if rulers violate rights, citizens have the moral right of revolution. > > • Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1712–1778) — The Prophet of Popular Sovereignty: In 'The Social Contract' (1762), declared: 'Man is born free, and everywhere he is in chains.' Denounced private property as the root of inequality in his 'Discourse on Inequality'. Sovereignty cannot be represented or alienated; it resides perpetually in the 'General Will' (volonté générale) aimed at the common good. > > • Comparative Dichotomy: Locke emphasized negative liberty (freedom from state encroachment, defense of property, representative parliamentary rule); Rousseau championed positive liberty (moral autonomy achieved through active participation in the civic community, subordinating private interest to collective welfare). > > • European Historical Impact: Locke's thought anchored the English Bill of Rights (1689), Montesquieu's separation of powers, and the American Revolution (1776); Rousseau's thought inspired the French Jacobins (Robespierre's 'Republic of Virtue'), 19th-century Romanticism, and modern democratic and socialist theory. >

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1. CONCEPTUAL MIND MAP & THEMATIC PATHWAY ```

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PHILOSOPHER STATE OF NATURE SOCIAL CONTRACT GOAL POLITICAL LEGACY

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JOHN LOCKE --> [State of Reason] --> [Fiduciary Trust to --> [Liberal Constitutionalism] (1632-1704) [Natural Rights: Protect Life, Liberty, [Limited Government / Rule of Law] Life/Liberty/Property] & Property] [Right of Revolution (1689/1776)]

JEAN-JACQUES --> [Noble Savage] --> [Total Alienation of --> [Radical Popular Sovereignty] ROUSSEAU [Corrupted by Private Will to the [Direct Participatory Democracy] (1712-1778) Civil Society & General Will [Jacobin Republic of Virtue (1793)] Private Property] (Volonté Générale)] [Romanticism & Modern Socialism]

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2. CHRONOLOGICAL MILESTONES & DIPLOMATIC DATES | Date / Year | Event / Action | Historical & Exam Significance | |---|---|---| | **1689 | Locke's Two Treatises of Government | Published anonymously; demolishes divine right absolutism; establishes natural rights and social compact. | | **1690** | Locke's Essay Concerning Human Understanding | Articulates 'tabula rasa' (blank slate); destroys scholastic dogmatism; elevates empirical reason. | | **1754** | Rousseau's Discourse on Inequality | Argues that civil society, private property, and institutional laws generated human inequality and moral decay. | | **1762** | Rousseau's The Social Contract | Opens with immortal phrase: 'Man is born free, and everywhere he is in chains'; formulates General Will. | | **1776** | American Declaration of Independence | Thomas Jefferson directly adapts Locke's triad into 'Life, Liberty, and the pursuit of Happiness'. | | **1789** | Declaration of the Rights of Man | Synthesizes Locke (Articles 1-2 on natural liberty/property) and Rousseau (Article 6: 'Law is expression of General Will'). | | **1793–1794** | Jacobin Reign of Terror | Maximilien Robespierre applies Rousseau's General Will to justify eliminating counter-revolutionary 'enemies of virtue'. | | **19th Cent.** | Divergent Ideological Evolution | Locke becomes intellectual father of European Classical Liberalism; Rousseau becomes catalyst for Democratic Socialism & Romanticism. |**

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3. THE 20-MARK MASTER MODEL ESSAY (~650 WORDS)

Introduction: The Philosophical Revolution of European Politics The transformation of European political thought from medieval theocratic absolutism into modern democratic constitutionalism was engineered primarily through the intellectual breakthroughs of John Locke and Jean-Jacques Rousseau. Prior to the seventeenth century, European monarchical legitimacy rested upon the divine right of kings, patriarchal authority (as expounded by Sir Robert Filmer), and the pessimistic Leviathan state of Thomas Hobbes. Locke and Rousseau completely subverted this paradigm by constructing secular, contractarian frameworks grounded in the concept of the 'State of Nature.' However, while both philosophers agreed that legitimate governance must originate from the consent of the governed, they diverged profoundly in their conception of human nature, liberty, and the state. John Locke articulated the foundational principles of individualistic classical liberalism, private property, and limited constitutional government, whereas Jean-Jacques Rousseau pioneered a radical, communitarian critique of civil society that enthroned inalienable popular sovereignty and the 'General Will,' forever altering the political landscape of the West.

Part (a) John Locke: Natural Rights, Constitutionalism, and the Right of Revolution John Locke's monumental contribution to European political thought, principally articulated in his 'Two Treatises of Government' (1689), served as the definitive philosophical justification for England's Glorious Revolution of 1688. Locke began by rejecting the Hobbesian premise that the State of Nature was a brutal condition of 'war of all against all.' Instead, Locke posited a pre-political state governed by natural law and reason, wherein all human beings were born equal and endowed by their Creator with inherent, inalienable 'Natural Rights' to 'Life, Liberty, and Estate (Property).' For Locke, property was not a concession granted by a monarch, but an innate natural right established whenever a human being 'mixes his labor' with the natural world. However, because the State of Nature lacked impartial judges and established laws to resolve disputes, individuals voluntarily entered into a 'Social Compact' to form a civil government.

Crucially, Locke redefined the state as a conditional 'fiduciary trust.' Government was created for one specific purpose: the preservation of citizens' natural rights. If a monarch or legislature degenerates into tyranny, exercises arbitrary power, or confiscates property without consent, that government breaches its trust and dissolves its own legitimacy. Under such circumstances, Locke affirmed the radical constitutional doctrine of the 'Appeal to Heaven'—the moral right of the people to resist tyranny and overthrow the regime through revolution. Furthermore, to prevent the concentration of arbitrary power, Locke advocated the institutional separation of legislative and executive powers, laying the blueprint for modern constitutional checks and balances. His empiricist epistemology in 'An Essay Concerning Human Understanding' (1690), presenting the human mind as a 'tabula rasa' (blank slate) shaped by experience rather than innate sin, democratized education and inspired the entire European Enlightenment.

Part (b) Jean-Jacques Rousseau: The Critique of Property and the 'General Will' Writing in the mid-eighteenth century, Jean-Jacques Rousseau executed an intellectual counter-revolution against both absolute monarchy and bourgeois rationalism. In his 'Discourse on the Origin of Inequality' (1754), Rousseau presented a radical anthropological critique of modern civilization. In Rousseau's State of Nature, man was not an aggressive Hobbesian brute nor an acquisitive Lockean property-owner, but a peaceful, compassionate 'noble savage' guided by self-preservation (amour de soi) and pity (pitié). The catastrophic fall of humanity occurred with the introduction of private property and metallurgy: 'The first man who, having enclosed a piece of ground, bethought himself of saying This is mine, and found people simple enough to believe him, was the real founder of civil society.' For Rousseau, modern civil society had institutionalized inequality, moral vanity (amour-propre), and psychological enslavement.

To resolve this existential tragedy, Rousseau published 'The Social Contract' (1762), opening with the electrifying indictment: 'Man is born free, and everywhere he is in chains.' Rousseau's solution was not a retreat to primitive savagery, but the creation of a legitimate, moral political community. He proposed that each individual surrender their particular, selfish ego to the collective whole, creating a sovereign body governed by the 'General Will' (volonté générale). The General Will is not simply the majority vote (which Rousseau called the 'will of all'), but the collective interest directed exclusively toward the common good. In obeying the General Will, the citizen obeys only themselves, achieving a higher, moral freedom. For Rousseau, sovereignty is completely indivisible, inalienable, and cannot be represented by parliamentary deputies; he favored direct, participatory democracy in the tradition of the ancient Greek polis and Swiss cantons.

Comparative Synthesis and Enduring European Impact The intellectual divergence between Locke and Rousseau generated two competing streams of modern European political culture. Locke provided the intellectual cornerstone for the Anglo-American tradition of 'Negative Liberty'—the protection of the private individual from state coercion, the sanctity of contract, the rule of law, and parliamentary representation. Locke's ideas directly inspired Baron de Montesquieu in France and Thomas Jefferson in the United States, who immortalized Locke's natural rights in the Declaration of Independence (1776). In contrast, Rousseau pioneered the

continental tradition of 'Positive Liberty'—freedom realized through active democratic citizenship and subordination to the common good. Rousseau's egalitarian ethos ignited the radical phase of the French Revolution; Maximilien Robespierre worshipped Rousseau, using the concept of the General Will to justify the Jacobin 'Republic of Virtue' and eliminate counter-revolutionary dissenters who refused to be 'forced to be free.'

Conclusion: The Dual Architects of Modern Political Thought In conclusion, John Locke and Jean-Jacques Rousseau irrevocably dismantled the philosophical foundations of absolute dynastic Europe. Locke stripped kings of their divine right, elevating the individual as the bearer of inviolable natural rights and making governance conditional upon constitutional consent. Rousseau diagnosed the moral bankruptcy of commercial society, elevating the collective Nation as the sole fountain of legitimate sovereignty and establishing the moral imperative of equality. When the French National Assembly convened in 1789, it fused these two titanic thinkers in the 'Declaration of the Rights of Man': Articles 1 and 2 enshrined Locke's natural rights to liberty and property, while Article 6 directly cited Rousseau in declaring that 'Law is the expression of the General Will.' Together, Locke and Rousseau forged the intellectual architecture of modern European democracy, constitutionalism, and human freedom.

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4. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PERSPECTIVES & SCHOLARLY QUOTES | Historian | Analytical Perspective | Exact Quotable Argument | |---|---|---| | **Isaiah Berlin | Two Concepts of Liberty | 'Locke is the greatest champion of negative liberty—the area within which a man can act unobstructed by others. Rousseau, in advocating positive liberty and the General Will, created a doctrine that could be used to justify tyranny in the name of true freedom.' | | **C.B. Macpherson** | Marxist Critique of Locke | 'Locke's state of nature is an early market society; his social contract was designed fundamentally to provide a constitutional defense for possessive individualism and unequal capitalist property.' | | **Ernst Cassirer** | Moral Reconstruction of Rousseau | 'Rousseau did not wish to return to the state of nature... He sought to transform society from an arena of exploitation into a genuine moral community where freedom and law are reconciled.' | | **Peter Gay** | Enlightenment Synthesis | 'Locke provided the Enlightenment with its method and its political common sense; Rousseau gave it its conscience, its passion, and its revolutionary fire.' |**
